A failed payment can cost one sale. An unexplained failure can cost the next one too.

ONSALE is a ticketing prototype built around a narrow question: once a buyer has scarce inventory and reaches Pay, can the product protect that opportunity without inventing certainty?

I arrived at that question through ticket drops I have tried to enter myself, from FIFA World Cup windows to Kanye and Kendrick Lamar concerts. Official inventory can disappear while a fan is still deciding what to do next. A broken checkout is more than an inconvenience in that moment. The hold is expiring, the buyer cannot tell whether money moved, and the resale market may be the only remaining path.

Payment is not the whole ticketing problem. Ticketmaster's account of the Eras Tour onsale describes extraordinary request volume, passcode errors, queue pressure, and fans losing tickets they had carted.[1] It does not identify a processor failure. Bots, access control, inventory, and queueing can defeat a buyer before checkout begins. That counterargument made the product choice more precise: ONSALE starts after a buyer has earned the right to buy and the merchant has something valuable to lose.

The merchant-side evidence is concrete. Eventbrite calls processing fees its largest cost-of-net-revenue component and says it keeps multiple payment integrations active for backup processing.[2] That filing does not prove demand for Hyperswitch. It does show that payment cost, provider dependence, and redundancy are already operating decisions inside a scaled ticketing business.

The deeper problem appears when several systems disagree about what happened. Airbnb's payments team describes timely payment state as difficult to obtain across a distributed ecosystem and warns that weak tracking can cause lost revenue or higher costs.[3] A response can disappear after the provider has already acted. Treating silence as failure may create a second charge. Treating silence as success may issue inventory that was never paid for. Waiting without explanation leaves the buyer and operator guessing.

Visibility matters when it changes the next decision: retrieve, wait, ask for a new method, or stop.

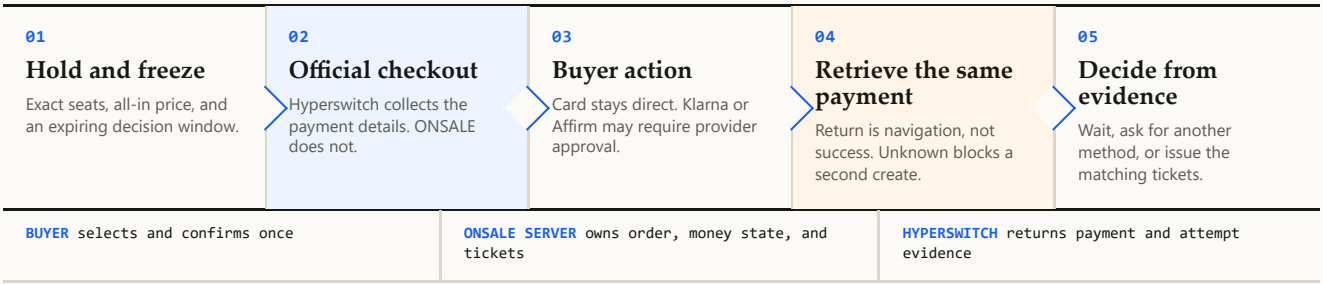
This is where visibility becomes product value. It tells the merchant what the system knows, what remains unknown, and which action is safe. That distinction makes recovery possible without a blind retry. It is designed to preserve the sale opportunity and give the operator a bounded next action. The buyer experiences the same architecture as continuity: a held order, an honest status, and a checkout that returns to the right place.

The target is deliberately small: high-demand US onsales where a valid hold reaches payment, time matters, and payment ambiguity can still destroy a legitimate purchase. ONSALE does not solve bots, resale fraud, or inventory scarcity. It asks what a payment product should do once those systems have done their job.

WHAT I CHOSE TO BUILD

Reliability has to be felt before it can be inspected.

One order and one payment identity move forward only when the next actor has enough evidence.



Cards exercise the direct path. Klarna and Affirm exercise approval and return. Google Pay and PayPal render in the official checkout, but no completed wallet payment is claimed. The only observed connector is `stripe_test`; no live routing decision is inferred.

The buyer flow begins with a fictional event, bounded inventory, an access check, and an expiring hold. The all-in amount appears before payment consent, a choice reinforced by the federal rule that the final payment amount must be at least as prominent as the total price.[4]

Hyperswitch's official fields keep card and wallet credentials outside ONSALE. One server-owned payment identity then survives submission, provider action, return, refresh, and reconciliation. Retrieval maps the returned state into a small set the product can act on without converting silence into either success or failure.

The payment explanation shows the current handoff, the evidence behind it, and what the system refused to infer. Deeper inspection remains available in Flows, where the selected method and observed sandbox connector stay separate facts. A buyer can choose Klarna while the returned record names `stripe_test`; that does not prove an issuer, card network, or intelligent routing decision.

Saved payments and Story Lab answer different questions. Previous Runs reads sanitized records from completed and incomplete sandbox payments. Story Lab contains six deterministic worked examples that isolate decisions such as a hard decline, provider approval, a lost response, and method-versus-connector behavior. The product never substitutes a simulation when saved records are unavailable.

Hyperswitch earned its place conditionally. It gave ONSALE an official checkout boundary, a server-side payment lifecycle, provider action, retrieval, and a way to inspect method and connector evidence without letting the browser decide money truth. That is useful for a merchant that needs an independent control layer across processors and can carry the integration burden. It is not the only credible choice. Stripe, Spreedly, and Primer document serious alternatives.[5]

The architecture is a product promise with limits: keep the order stable, make uncertainty visible, recover the same payment, and fulfill only from returned evidence. It does not promise that every payment will succeed.

WHAT THE EVAL TAUGHT ME

The eval asks whether the product knows when not to retry.

1 payment identity	0 duplicate creates
1 charged attempt	Q = T quantity equals tickets
SIM deterministic population	

The most revealing case begins with one ordinary action: the buyer clicks Pay once. The provider may have acted, but the merchant receives no trustworthy answer. At that point a fresh payment request is dangerous. The product freezes new submission, keeps the original order and payment identity, and retrieves before it considers creating anything else.

The outcome is a set of customer consequences. The buyer is never told that silence means success. An issuer decline stays distinct from an unknown transport result. A second payment identity is not created while the first outcome remains unresolved. Tickets appear only after one charged attempt is supported and ticket count equals order quantity. The saved record must also give an operator a useful explanation of what happened and what to do next.

That is why this is an eval rather than a test case. Tests can prove that an identifier is reused, a cookie survives return, a duplicate command is blocked, or a ticket row is written. The eval asks whether those mechanisms work together to protect the buyer and give the merchant a safe decision under uncertainty. It measures payment identities, duplicate creates, charged attempts, ticket cardinality, and explanation quality. Today the case is demonstrated through deterministic integration behavior and Story Lab simulation. It is not production recovery uplift.

A lost response is retrieved, not retried.

The same discipline shaped what I deferred. Routing stays deterministic because the prototype can explain one payment safely, but cannot prove that a second connector would improve approval or cost. Automatic retry stays out because a technical failure, an issuer decline, and a missing response demand different actions. Aggregate success rates stay out because a few sandbox records have no population, window, or counterfactual.

The strongest falsifier is practical. If a target merchant has one processor, little ambiguity in payment state, and no material cost from reconciliation or switching, an orchestration layer adds complexity without earning its place. The Hyperswitch choice also weakens if the merchant's integrated processor already supplies the required methods, state model, recovery controls, and visibility with less operating burden.

The next question for Juspay is which routing policy becomes worth testing once the evidence is trustworthy. Production observations could eventually support policy by amount, method, region, cost, or acceptance, but only after the merchant defines the objective and a comparison population can detect harm.[6]

Google's AP2 v0.2 already imagines an agent buying a limited-run ticket under pre-authorized instructions.[7] The question is whether the same stable order, scoped authority, and recovery evidence can keep that delegated purchase accountable when no person is watching checkout.

I began with the fear that a scarce ticket could disappear inside an ambiguous payment. The build changed the question. Trust does not come from promising that failure is impossible. It comes from making the system's knowledge legible, preserving the buyer's place, and knowing when the safest action is to wait, retrieve, or stop.

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